Breaking Into Big Law

A Practical Guide for First Year Law Students

9 NOVEMBER 2026

“知己知彼，百战不殆。”

Know yourself and know the other side, and in a hundred battles you will never be in peril.

孙子 SUN TZU

WHEN SOMEONE ASKS A 1L what kind of lawyer they want to become, the question can sound as if the student should already understand the work, the firms doing it, and where they would like to spend the next several years. And if you have just started learning how to read a case, there is a pretty obvious gap between what you know and what the conversation seems to expect from you, not to mention that law firms have been gradually changing their recruiting strategies over the past 3 years. All of this arrives alongside cold calls, a new way of reading and writing, and your first exams, so if you feel behind, that feeling says more about the timing than about you. We remember that pressure well. I do think we can make these conversations more useful, but it starts with being honest about what we have not figured out, rather than finding a more impressive way to describe a career we have not tried.

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01

The Recruiting Calendar

Nothing in this chapter is a deadline we set. It is an account of a calendar that has moved in each of the last two years, and of the school policies that are trying to hold it still.

Most of this guide is about how to think. This chapter is about when, because a 1L can think clearly all year and still miss the window.

Recruiting for the 2L summer used to run through on-campus interviews in the autumn of 2L year. It does not any more. It now happens during 1L, and it has kept moving earlier inside 1L in each of the last two cycles.

Two members of this committee went through it one class year apart and did not describe the same thing. We are giving you both rather than averaging them.

IN PRACTICE, THE 2024–25 CYCLE

After my 1L fall finals, I spent about a day submitting all my Big Law summer associate applications. I applied to both 1L and 2L positions, depending on what was available. Before applying, I asked my career advisor to review my resume and cover letter so that I had everything ready to go. I found the resources on Career Space very helpful, especially the sample resumes and cover letters, which give you a good sense of the expected format and structure. I received most of my interview invitations in mid-to-late 1L spring and completed my interviews before spring finals. I was fortunate enough to receive a couple of offers before finals, which definitely helped reduce my stress during exam season.

IN PRACTICE, THE 2025–26 CYCLE

By my year the applications were open before the semester was over. Most firms opened around the first of November, and the earliest opened in the middle of October. A firm that was interested sent a screener within about a week of receiving the application, and a callback followed roughly one to two weeks after that. The screeners and callbacks ran from November into January. Firms work through applications broadly in the order they arrive, so submitting late does not just delay your own interview, it puts you into a thinner part of the season.

Separate two things here: what we know, and what these two accounts on their own can show you. What we know is that the calendar moved, and fast. Between one class year and the next, firms pulled their recruiting months earlier, and in the cycle after these two accounts some firms were opening in late October. That is this committee's own observation of three consecutive years, not arithmetic done on the two notes above.

What the two notes can show you is narrower, because they are not measuring the same thing. The first says when that person submitted. The second says when the firms opened, and someone can submit in January to a portal that opened in November. Read them as two people describing the years they went through, one after the other, rather than as the evidence for the sentence above.

Two things follow. The first is that being ready before the window opens is the part of this you control, and being ready means having a resume someone has already read, a cover letter you are not writing for the first time, and a list of firms you can act on in a day. The second is that you cannot take this chapter, or any other guide, as the authority on dates. Check the firms' own pages and your own school's policy for the year you are actually in. We are showing you how fast this moves precisely so that you do not trust a printed calendar, including ours.

Who sets these dates

NALP publishes principles, not a start date. Your school may publish a date, and that one binds you.

If the dates can sit this early, it is fair to ask who is in charge of them. The short answer is that nobody is, in the sense a 1L would want, but your own school comes closest.

NALP, the National Association for Law Placement, publishes Principles for a Fair and Ethical Recruitment Process. They are, in NALP's own description, suggested best practices. They do not name a date on which recruiting may begin. What they do instead is ask employers and schools to establish and maintain their own guidelines, publish them, and then act consistently with what they published.

What the Principles ask of employers is worth knowing, because it tells you what you are entitled to expect rather than what you must accept. Employers are asked to schedule recruiting so as to minimize interference with students' academic work and exam periods, to exercise particular sensitivity during the first semester of law school and respect each school's own 1L guidelines, to give candidates a reasonable period of time to consider an offer, to give consideration to reasonable requests for an extension, and to avoid conduct that places undue pressure on a candidate to accept or decline. In a statement issued in April 2026, NALP repeated those points and said it was concerned that some current practices were putting undue pressure on students.

Notice what is absent from all of that: a number. The Principles say reasonable and do not say how many days. That does not mean no number exists anywhere. It means NALP is not the place to look for one.

The rule that does bind you is your own school's, and school policies are far more specific than the Principles are. They are addressed to employers as well as to you, so a firm that recruits at your school is being asked to follow them.

Northwestern's are a worked example rather than a national standard, and they are the ones this guide knows best. As published on 9 November 2026, they ask employers not to begin formal one-to-one recruiting with 1Ls — applications, interviews or offers — before 1 November, and not to hold first-year networking events before 15 September. They ask that an offer of 1L summer employment stay open at least fourteen days. For 2L summer offers made before first semester grades are released, they ask that the offer be held open until at least 1 February; made after grades, until the later of fourteen days or 1 February. They ask employers to grant written requests for an extension of at least a further seven days. And they limit students to holding three open offers at once.

How much any of that binds a firm is a fair question, and the answer is: less than it reads. These are policies a school addresses to the employers who recruit there. A firm that does not come to your school for interviews or receptions has no particular reason to follow them, and the school's leverage is its own recruiting relationship rather than anything enforceable. Treat them as the standard you can point to when you ask for more time, not as a guarantee that you will get it.

Two things to take from that. The first is that if you are told you have three days to decide, that is still worth a call to your career office rather than a panicked yes, because at many schools it sits below what the school has asked employers to do, and that is a thing your adviser can raise. The second is what has happened to the date itself: the first of November is what Northwestern asks employers to wait for, and in the most recent cycle some firms opened in late October. Take from that what you like about how much the ask holds. The practical consequence is that you cannot plan around a date someone else has promised to respect.

Find out what your own school's policy says before you act on anything else in this chapter. If a firm's deadline falls before the date your school allows, that is a conversation to have with your career office, not a decision to make by yourself at midnight.

None of which means a later application is wasted. People in both of the accounts above ended up with offers.

One more thing about the day you submit, because the fear of getting it wrong is larger than the consequence usually is.

IN PRACTICE

A quick funny story: I actually misspelled my email address on my resume (I spelled "Northwestern" wrong, lol), and I completely freaked out when I realized it. But I still received interview invitations. So two lessons here. First, double-check your email address before submitting anything. Second, even if you make a mistake, it is not necessarily the end of the world, although it might feel like it at the time.

02

What Grades Decide

The honest version is that grades matter, that they are not the only thing, and that neither half of that sentence is much use without the other.

Grades are the loudest question in most 1L rooms. A guide that steps around them is not being kind, it is being evasive, so here is the honest version in two halves.

Here is the part that is uncomfortable and true. Grades carry real weight in recruiting. The move to a 1L fall calendar means many people now apply before their first set of grades exists, which sounds as though grades have stopped mattering, but they have not. Once first semester results arrive, they still count, and for some firms they count a great deal.

Here is the other part, which is just as true. A disappointing first semester is not a verdict. The paths people take from there are well worn: a mid-size firm or a secondary market, applying again in 2L, and strengthening the rest of the record through journal or moot court. These are not consolation prizes. They are how a large number of practising lawyers actually got where they are.

One mechanism is worth understanding, because it is invisible from the outside. An offer you already hold changes how other firms treat you. It is evidence that someone has evaluated you and said yes, and it often moves a firm that is still deciding, because the alternative is losing a candidate who has

somewhere else to go. A first offer is therefore not only a result. It is sometimes the thing that makes the next conversation possible.

We are describing a mechanism, not handing you a plan. It only works if there is something real behind you at each step, we cannot tell you how often it succeeds, and pursuing it carries an obvious risk, which is losing an offer you would have been glad to accept. Read it as a reason to keep going after a bad semester rather than as a technique to execute.

What we would not do is let a bad semester decide what you apply for. The cost of applying is an evening. The cost of assuming you are out is the whole cycle.

IN PRACTICE

Grades matter more than almost anything else at this stage, so study hard and try to get the best grades you can. Your grades will have a significant impact on the opportunities available to you. Practice your interview skills too. Being a strong interviewer can help make up for less-than-perfect grades and may help you land better offers. How you present yourself and connect with the interviewer can make a real difference.

03

Understanding Law Firms

What kinds of law firms will I come across

Everyone wants to work at a good law firm.

When someone says a firm is "good," I would first ask what they mean, because a firm can be well known for major business transactions, strong in a particular local market, or excellent at a specialized kind of litigation, and those descriptions do not tell us the same thing. The categories below are ways to get oriented, not a ranking or a set of boxes every firm fits into perfectly.

1 Large firms with many practices may have offices across the country or internationally, and can bring different specialists into the same matter. If you are interested in how several areas of law fit together on business problems, that breadth is worth investigating, but it does not mean every practice exists in every office or that a junior can freely move between them.

2 Regional and midsized firms may offer a range of services while concentrating more of their work in particular markets. I would ask about their actual clients and matters rather than assume a less familiar name means less sophisticated work, lower expectations, or easier recruiting.

3 Specialist firms, often called boutiques, concentrate on particular work, such as litigation, tax, intellectual property, or employment. "Boutique" describes focus more usefully than size, and some specialist firms have substantial teams across several offices. That focus can be attractive if you understand

what you want to explore, though you should check how much room there is to try something else.

4 Small firms and local practices can serve individuals, smaller businesses, or highly specialized clients, sometimes with a broad practice and sometimes with a narrow one. I would investigate the supervision and resources available rather than assume that a smaller team automatically gives a new lawyer better responsibility or better hours.

There are other distinctions inside these categories. A litigation firm might represent businesses defending claims, people bringing claims, or different clients on different matters, which can change the work and business model without fitting neatly into a size category. Government, public interest organizations, courts, and legal departments inside companies also employ lawyers, but they are different kinds of employers rather than lower tiers of law firms.

The three differences I would compare first

Do not look only at the rankings. A ranking measures just one dimension of a law firm.

1 What work does the firm do, and for whom? Look at the clients and problems the particular practice handles, then ask what portion reaches a junior's desk. A recognizable client does not explain your assignment, and "litigation" does not yet tell you which disputes, which side, or what role you might play. I would begin here because an impressive workplace can still be a poor match for work I do not enjoy.

2 Where does that capability sit, and how is the team organized? A firm's overall reach is different from the depth of the group in your target office. Ask whether the lawyers you would work with are local, how they work across offices, and how staffing is controlled. If Firm A has a famous name but the practice you want sits elsewhere, while Firm B has an established team in your city, that is a reason to ask better questions about both firms, not automatically choose either one.

3 What would the junior experience actually involve? Compare the available information about assignments, supervision, feedback, compensation,

expectations, and room to explore, keeping confirmed terms separate from recruiting impressions. A billing rate tells you what a client is charged, not what you will earn or how well you will be trained. I would not turn size, revenue, prestige, or a high rate into a shortcut for the experience I am trying to understand.

These are my first 3 comparison lenses, not the 3 measures that produce an objective winner. Someone who wants to explore several practices and someone already committed to a specialist field may reasonably prefer different opportunities, even after looking at the same information.

Where I would look for firms and how I would use the sources

TL;DR: the career office, the firm's website, and alumni.

IN PRACTICE

Talk to someone one on one > go to a reception > Chambers Associate >>>> Vault. And send cold emails. If you get ignored, do not take it personally, just find another person. They receive more than 100 emails a day even when they are not busy.

1 Start with the career office at your law school. Ask which employers have recruited students from your school, which offices are relevant to your interests, and what employer information you can access. This helps you build a list connected to your circumstances, although past hiring does not establish your own chances or future vacancies.

2 Read the firm's official office, practice, people, and student recruiting pages together. A practice description helps identify work, an attorney biography helps identify people, and the recruiting page is where I would check the program and application instructions. A public matter description can give you a question to ask, but a marketing page is not independent proof of training quality or a promise that you will do that work.

3 Use Chambers to investigate recognition in the relevant practice and market, and read its methodology so you understand that the research includes firm submissions and reference interviews. Check the guide year and geographic

scope instead of turning one ranked practice into a claim about the whole firm. A ranking can help you discover names; it does not certify the summer program or tell you that an unranked firm is a bad employer.

4 Use alumni conversations to test what the written material leaves unanswered. Northwestern's alumni page links to its directory; ask the school which networking resources are available to current students rather than assume every alumni tool is open to you. LinkedIn and discussion forums can suggest people or questions to investigate, but a profile can be outdated and an anonymous account is not verification of a firm's policy or culture.

5 Use resources such as Vault as another route into employer research, but check what a particular ranking measures before using it to compare firms. Prestige, practice recognition, and employee experience are different questions, and I would not combine their scores as if they measured the same thing. I would spend more time on specific comments about the work, training, and office than on the difference between 2 positions in a ranking, because those details can give me something to investigate. A ranking can be useful marketing material for a firm without answering whether I would want to work there, though a detailed comment is still an account to check, not a verified description of everyone's experience. Some information may require an account or subscription, so check what your school provides before paying for access.

6 Ask the career office about employer directories, including the NALP Directory of Legal Employers, as another starting point for finding participating employers. Check the office, reporting date, and available information against the firm's current materials. A missing directory entry does not establish that a firm is poor or that it does not hire students. The directory's live contents could not be checked for this draft, so confirm access before relying on it for a particular detail.

For each firm, I would keep one simple record: the office and practice, why it interests me, the source and date of that information, someone I could learn from, and the next thing to verify. Start with a manageable list and expand it with your career adviser, rather than assuming the most familiar names are the entire market.

How I would find attorneys and make the first connection

Attorneys do not turn into strangers or monsters just because they became attorneys. Think about how you make a new friend, because the method is the same.

Once you have an office and practice in mind, search the firm's people page for lawyers who actually work there, then look for a connection that makes the conversation relevant, such as your school, a previous field of work, or a genuine interest in their practice. A junior associate may be well placed to describe early assignments, while a more senior lawyer can offer a different perspective on the practice. I would choose the person for the question, not simply contact whoever has the most senior title.

Check their current firm biography before writing, use a publicly listed professional contact or a school approved channel, and make a small request that someone can reasonably answer. An alumni connection gives you a reason to introduce yourself, not an entitlement to their time. If there is no reply, one courteous follow up can be reasonable; after that, move on rather than contacting several people to pressure the same person.

For example, you could write, "Hi [Name], I'm a 1L at Northwestern, and I saw that you also attended Northwestern and now work in [practice] in [office]. I'm trying to understand [specific question], and your work on [verified public topic] caught my attention. Would you have 15 minutes for a conversation sometime in the next 2 weeks? I understand if your schedule does not allow it." Only include the shared connection and public topic if they are true, and leave either out if you do not have it.

If the goal is to apply, follow the firm's application instructions separately. A lawyer agreeing to speak with you does not replace an application, guarantee a referral, or authorize you to describe them as recommending you. After a useful conversation, thank them for something specific you learned and record the next action, which is how the connection becomes part of your thinking rather than another name collected.

IN PRACTICE

Always ask them to chat and offer help. They want to talk about their work and they want someone who can help in the future. It is absolutely fine if you know nothing about the practice, as long as you are interested, because it is always easier for midlevels to do the work themselves. They want to invest in you so that they have a good junior later. Just ask. Nobody cares if you have no background.

IN PRACTICE

I also did some cold emailing, because I personally found large networking events a little overwhelming. There were often too many students and too few attorneys, which made it difficult to have meaningful conversations. My strategy was to reach out to Northwestern alumni, since I figured they would be more likely to respond. And if someone does not respond, do not take it personally. They are probably just busy.

How associate pay works

Lockstep means the number is set by your class year, not by you.

Associate pay at large firms usually follows a class-year scale, often called lockstep: the base is set by the year you graduated rather than negotiated individually, and it rises on a published schedule as the class advances. How widely that scale reaches is not uniform. It can differ by office, by track, by the class year a firm credits you with, and by conditions a particular firm attaches, so check the terms for the office and the position rather than assuming one number covers everyone.

The figure moves when one firm raises it and others match. Matching is neither automatic nor quick: some firms move within weeks, some take months, and some do not match at all. As of June 2026, Milbank set a new scale with a first-year base of $235,000, and Norton Rose Fulbright followed. We are giving you one dated reference point rather than a full table, because the table would be wrong by the time you read it.

Two cautions. Bonuses sit on top of base and follow their own announcements. And lockstep is a large-firm convention, not a law: mid-size firms, secondary markets and non-equity tracks may set pay differently.

04

Choosing the Work

Q1 How do I choose an area of law when I have barely studied law

Trust me, you do not need to know which area of law you will ultimately choose when you are a 1L. Someone who sounds completely certain may have real experience behind that choice, or they may still be living in their law school personal statement. And if they really have figured it out, go make friends with them, because I would like to hear how they managed it.

If we think about why a practice sounds interesting, we may be responding to the industry, the client, or a case we read about, which is not necessarily the same thing as being interested in the work a junior lawyer would do on it. Someone can be genuinely interested in businesses without knowing whether they would enjoy revising an agreement, working through a disputed record, or researching a regulatory question. I would start with that difference before trying to decide whether I am a "corporate person" or a "litigation person."

A useful question for an associate is, "Could you walk me through a recent assignment you are allowed to discuss, including what you produced and how it was reviewed?" Once you have a concrete example, you can compare it with something you have actually enjoyed doing and ask what you are missing. For now, I would choose 2 or 3 areas to explore through conversations, courses, or public materials, and let the interest become more specific as you understand the work. You do not need to turn an early preference into a permanent identity.

Q2 How do I choose a practice group within a firm

You will hear people divide legal work into transactional work and litigation, but the choices are more complicated than those 2 labels suggest. Transactional lawyers help clients structure, negotiate, and document arrangements such as acquisitions, financings, and commercial agreements. Litigators handle disputes, which can involve investigating facts, researching legal questions, writing briefs, negotiating settlements, and appearing in court, though not every matter reaches trial. Each category contains different practices, and work such as regulatory advice can connect with both without fitting neatly into either one.

So when a firm says you can join its corporate practice, I would want to understand what "corporate" means in that office and how someone gets from being a summer associate to doing particular work. The label alone does not answer whether you will rotate, receive assignments through a coordinator, or need to express a preference before you have much exposure, and those differences matter if you are still exploring.

I would ask, "How does a summer associate here get exposure to different groups, and when does the placement decision actually happen?" If the answer sounds flexible, the next question is what that flexibility looks like in practice, including who helps when an interest changes. You are not being difficult by asking how the process works. At the same time, I would keep a positive recruiting conversation separate from a placement commitment, and confirm any specific program terms with the person responsible for them before treating them as part of the offer.

IN PRACTICE

I was already leaning toward transactional work, but I also wanted some exposure to litigation, so I took on some pro bono litigation work. I would recommend that to anyone in a similar position. I personally felt a little less pressure exploring an unfamiliar practice area through pro bono assignments, although that certainly does not mean the work is any less important, or that you should be any less careful with it.

Q3 How do I choose a firm without just following prestige

I can understand why someone would begin with prestige, especially when a familiar name gives them something to compare before they know much about the work. I do not think that is a bad starting point, but if you expect to spend years practicing law, I would look beyond the name before deciding where to begin.

The person you work with and the assignments you receive will be much more specific than the firm's name. If you are comparing opportunities, I would put the office, practice, staffing process, and supervision next to each other, and leave space for what you still do not know rather than filling every box with an impression.

For example, "everyone seemed nice" tells you how a recruiting interaction felt, while an associate explaining who reviewed their first assignment and how they received comments gives you something you can ask another person about. Neither guarantees your experience, but the second conversation takes you further. I personally think prestige can be part of the discussion without doing all the thinking for us, and I would rather understand why a particular office makes sense for me than have a ranking I cannot connect to the work I hope to do.

Q4 How should I choose a city or office

This sounds like a simple question, but it is actually a bit philosophical. The question underneath it is what kind of life you want to live and what you are chasing, whether that is money, reputation, health, family, influence, or simply more control over your time. A city is more than the place you move to for a job, because you are also choosing an environment, a professional community, and some version of an ordinary day.

If you want to work on major business matters, I would investigate where the relevant clients and teams are rather than assume a city's reputation tells me what a particular office does. And if you want a balanced life (if there is one), moving to a different market does not by itself establish what your hours or responsibilities will be. I would ask about the actual work and expectations,

then consider what they would mean for sleep, relationships, and whether I would get outside and see some daylight. The tradeoffs are worth taking seriously, but "bigger city means bigger matters and less life" is too simple to make the decision for us.

If you are considering a city because the office has work you want to do, that is a real reason, and if your family, partner, or close friends are there, that is also a real reason. I do not think we need to turn the life we want outside work into something embarrassing to explain. Ask, "What about practicing here is different from the firm's other offices?" and consider the cost, daily routine, and support you would have when work becomes super hectic. If you are new to the market, explain your actual interest rather than invent ties, and investigate any future transfer possibility separately instead of treating it as an escape plan.

Q5 How do I evaluate a partner or team before joining

You may not be able to choose a particular partner or team before accepting a summer or permanent offer, but I would still think about supervision and staffing early rather than wait until the first assignment. The team you imagine joining and the process that assigns your work may be two different things, so first ask how much choice a new associate actually has. Once you understand who controls staffing, you can ask how instructions, draft review, and competing deadlines are handled, which gives you a better picture of supervision than a general question about whether the team is supportive.

Consider a junior who receives 2 assignments with the same deadline. I would want to know who helps resolve that conflict and whether the junior is expected to coordinate it alone, so I might ask, "When someone is staffed on matters with conflicting deadlines, how do they raise that and who helps prioritize?" During a summer, you can also observe how people respond when someone is unsure or makes a mistake. I would use those observations carefully, without turning diligence into gossip or treating one warm conversation with a partner as proof of what working together under pressure will be like.

05

Recruiting Conversations

Q6 What should I do at a reception

When you walk into a reception and see groups of lawyers already talking, it is easy to spend more time thinking about how to enter the conversation than listening once you are in it. I would give myself a smaller task: have a few conversations I can actually remember, rather than try to meet everyone before leaving. If a group looks open, wait for a pause and introduce yourself with your name, school, and something you are trying to learn. "I'm a 1L at Northwestern, and I've been trying to understand what junior work in your practice looks like" is enough to give the other person somewhere to start.

Then follow the answer instead of immediately moving to the next prepared question. If another student is waiting to join, make room, and when the conversation has run its course, you can say, "Thank you, that gives me something specific to look into. I'll let you catch up with the others." I do not think staying beside someone longer automatically makes the interaction better, and I would not treat drinking alcohol or acting unusually outgoing as part of the assignment. You are there to meet people, not to perform a version of yourself you cannot sustain.

IN PRACTICE

During 1L fall there were so many networking receptions, and it was easy to experience FOMO when everyone seemed to be attending everything. If you feel like going, you should absolutely take those opportunities. But based on my experience, grades still play a significant role in recruiting, and networking is more of a supplement than a substitute. If you are exhausted after a long day or have an assignment deadline coming up, do not feel pressured to attend every event. Be strategic instead. The large events where multiple firms are represented make it relatively easy to meet attorneys from several firms in one place.

IN PRACTICE

After an event, I would recommend sending a follow-up email thanking the attorneys for their time. If you are particularly interested in a firm or practice area, you can also ask whether they would be open to a follow-up coffee chat.

One contributor suggests a small habit that makes those follow-up emails much easier to write.

IN PRACTICE

Carry a small notebook, or use the notes app on your phone. After each conversation ends, write down the attorney's name, practice group and office, roughly what you talked about, and one or two specific details, such as the kind of deal they mentioned or a class they recommended. Later it lets your thank-you note refer to something real, and it gives you an honest answer when an interviewer asks why you are interested in that firm. Write it between conversations or off to one side, not while someone is talking to you. Asking for a business card and noting the details on the back works just as well.

A note on tools, since one has been offered to readers of this guide. DeepVista turns talking into notes. The use that fits this chapter is a narrow one: you leave the reception, and once you are home you say out loud what you remember — who you met, what they work on, the deal or the class they mentioned — and it files that into structured notes you can search weeks

later, when someone asks why that firm. It has a free tier, which is what has been offered to you, with paid tiers above it, at app.deepvista.ai. We mention it because it was offered to you, not because anyone here is paid for it, and a paper notebook does the same work.

Two things about using anything of this kind. Never record the conversation itself. What you are capturing is your own recollection, afterwards and alone — not the other person's words, and not the room. Recording laws vary from state to state. In Illinois, where much of this guide was written, secretly recording a private conversation without the consent of all parties can be a crime, and Illinois is not the only state like that. The rule that keeps you clear of all of it is the simple one: do not record recruiting conversations. The second thing is that tools of this kind generally also offer to plan and send sequences of messages on your behalf. That feature is built for sales, and it is the opposite of everything in this chapter. A third thing, for later: keep client names, matter details and anything else nonpublic out of a tool like this. Your own recollection of a conversation with a recruiter is yours to dictate. A note about a deal is not.

Q7 How do I make a coffee chat useful

If someone has agreed to give you time, I would do enough preparation that they do not have to repeat their website biography, but I would not prepare so rigidly that their answers cannot change the conversation. Explain why their experience interests you and what you have been trying to understand, then ask something they can answer from their own perspective, such as, "What did you misunderstand about this practice before you started doing it?"

The useful part may be the follow up. If they say the work surprised them, ask what was different and how they adjusted, rather than treating the first answer as a completed item on your list. As the agreed time approaches, acknowledge it and ask whether there is room for one more question. Afterward, a short thank you referring to something you actually learned is enough. And if you later act on their advice, that gives you a natural reason to update them, which is different from inventing messages just to stay visible. I would not assume the chat includes a referral or a recruiting

commitment, though if the person raises an opportunity, you can be direct about your interest.

IN PRACTICE

If you schedule a one-on-one coffee chat, make sure you come prepared. Look up the attorney's background on LinkedIn or their firm's website, learn a little about their practice, and prepare some thoughtful questions. Otherwise you might leave a less-than-ideal impression.

One practical note about the room itself. These conversations happen in public cafés in Streeterville and the Loop, and a bag hooked over the back of a chair is the easiest thing in the city to take. The method is unremarkable, which is the point: someone walks past with a coat folded over one arm, the coat is what hides the hand, and it is done between two sentences. Keep the bag on your lap or between your feet, and your phone off the table.

This is not a hypothetical. One of the conversations behind this guide ended that way. The wallet alone was worth more than a thousand dollars, and it was the smaller loss; what went with it was every piece of identification its owner was carrying, which takes weeks to replace and, where immigration documents are involved, on a timetable you do not control. We were told afterwards that the same people work that café regularly and that nobody has been arrested. Assume the room you are sitting in is somebody else's place of work too.

06

Questions Students Can Ask

If you meet one lawyer at a reception and later have one useful coffee chat, you already have somewhere to begin. I would not build a networking plan around reaching every level of a firm. Choose 2 or 3 questions that fit the conversation, listen to the answers, and leave the rest for another time. The senior attorney questions are there if the opportunity comes up, not because a 1L needs a partner meeting to make progress.

IN PRACTICE

Do not feel that every conversation has to be about legal work or Big Law. Lawyers are people, and sometimes they are perfectly happy just chatting about everyday life. Let the conversation develop naturally and focus on actually getting to know the person. I would also stay away from questions that may be a little too senior or sensitive for someone just starting out, such as partnership prospects, promotion decisions, or the internal politics around advancement.

At Receptions

These are easy ways to start talking without asking someone to give a presentation about their firm. Once a conversation gets going, you can follow what interests both of you rather than keep asking about work.

1 "What kind of work do you do at the firm?"

2 "How did you end up in that practice?"

3 "What do you enjoy most about the work?"

4 "What brought you to this city?"

5 "Was there anything about practice that surprised you after law school?"

6 "When you were a student, how did you figure out what interested you?"

7 "Have you been to one of these events before?"

8 "Is there anything you would suggest reading or attending to learn more about your practice?"

9 "What drew you to this firm?"

10 "What are you hoping to do more of in your work over the next 2 years?"

In One on One Coffee Chats

With a little more time, I would ask about the person's experience and use it to understand the choices in front of me. You can ask these questions of the lawyer you actually meet; you do not need a different contact for each topic. If something falls outside their experience, move on rather than expect them to speak for the firm.

11 "Could you walk me through a recent assignment you are allowed to discuss?"

12 "What do junior lawyers spend most of their time doing in your practice?"

13 "How is the work different from what you expected before joining?"

14 "What mattered most when you chose your firm, and would you weigh anything differently now?"

15 "How did you get your first assignments, and who helped you get started?"

16 "What kind of feedback helped you most when you were new?"

17 "If I am still deciding between practices, how would you suggest exploring them?"

18 "When assignments have competing deadlines, how does your team sort out priorities?"

19 "How does your office work with lawyers in the firm's other offices?"

20 "What do you wish you had asked before choosing a firm?"

If You Speak With a Senior Attorney

If you happen to speak with a senior associate, counsel, or partner who supervises others or has a broader view of the practice, these questions can make use of that perspective. I would still follow the setting: a brief introduction at a reception does not need to become an interview about how the firm is managed.

21 "What makes a junior lawyer someone you can rely on?"

22 "What makes an early draft useful to you, even when the person is still learning?"

23 "How can a junior judge when to keep working through a problem and when to ask for help?"

24 "When a junior makes a mistake, what do you hope they do next?"

25 "How do you make room for teaching and feedback when a matter gets busy?"

26 "What changes in your practice should someone entering it pay attention to?"

27 "If you were choosing where to begin your career today, what would you want to understand about the team?"

A follow up such as "What did that look like in practice?" can be more useful than another prepared question, as long as you leave room for the person not to discuss protected details. Keep formal eligibility, deadlines, compensation and program policy questions for the designated recruiting contact rather than expect a lawyer's personal experience to establish the rules.

07

Questions Attorneys May Ask Students

When someone at a reception asks how school is going, I would answer the conversation they are starting rather than reach for a prepared interview story. A scheduled interview calls for different preparation, especially when the question asks for a specific example of how you handled something. Questions about your interests can appear in either setting, but that does not mean every casual chat needs to sound like an interview.

The sample answers below are fictional illustrations of structure, not the editors' experiences or facts a student should borrow. Replace every bracket and personal detail with something true, and use your own words rather than memorize the samples.

Social Questions in Group Conversations or Casual Chats

I would keep these answers short enough for someone else to join in, and mention something I would actually enjoy discussing. You do not need to prove a professional strength every time you speak, though the setting still calls for judgment about what you share.

1 "How is your first year going?"

Answer with something specific rather than turn it into a performance review of yourself or your professors.

> *"I'm still getting used to the reading, but I've enjoyed seeing how people can read the same facts differently. [Class] has been especially interesting. What do you remember most about your first year?"*

2 "What brought you to this event?"

A real reason is enough; you do not need a polished statement about your commitment to the firm.

> *"I've been trying to learn more about [practice], and I thought this would be a good chance to talk with people doing the work. I'm still pretty early in figuring it out."*

3 "What kind of law are you thinking about?"

Name an interest and leave room for exploration. This can start a conversation without becoming a declaration of your permanent plans.

> *"I'm curious about [practice] because I enjoyed [real subject or experience], but I haven't seen enough of the work to know yet. How did you decide what you wanted to do?"*

4 "Are you from here?"

Share what you are comfortable sharing, and let the answer connect naturally to the city rather than manufacture a recruiting story.

> *"I grew up in [place] and moved here for law school. I've been enjoying [something true about the city], though there is still a lot I haven't explored. Have you been here long?"*

5 "What did you do before law school?"

Describe your actual background simply, including coming straight from college if that is your path. You do not need to make it sound more substantial than it was.

> *"I came straight from [college], where I studied [subject]. I also spent time on [real activity], which I enjoyed because [reason]. Law school has been a different kind of challenge."*

6 "What do you do when you are not studying?"

Let this be a human answer, not another argument for hiring you.

> *"I've been learning to cook a few dishes I grew up eating, and mine still taste different. It's been a good reason to have friends over and talk about something other than school."*

You can ask a question back when you are genuinely curious, but you do not need to attach one to every answer. In a group conversation, sometimes the better next step is simply to leave space for another person.

Questions in Interviews and Callbacks

Here I would prepare a small set of real experiences I can discuss clearly, particularly for the behavioral questions about teamwork, mistakes, feedback and deadlines. Give enough context to understand the problem, explain what you personally did, and say what happened or changed afterward. You do not need to announce a framework, invent a successful ending, or force the same story into every question. For motivation questions, connect an actual interest to something specific you have learned about the opportunity.

1 "Tell me about yourself."

I would connect the parts of my background that explain why I am here, rather than recite every line of the resume. A short answer should leave room for a follow up.

> *"I'm a 1L at Northwestern, and before law school I [actual background]. I became interested in [issue] through [real experience], which is why I've been exploring [practice]. I'm now trying to understand how that work looks inside a firm."*

2 "Why law?"

The useful part is the link between an experience and the work you want to learn, not claiming you have always loved arguments or already understand every part of practice.

> *"In [real setting], I kept coming back to questions about [issue], but my role did not let me work through the legal side. That made me want to study it more seriously, and [actual coursework or experience] has given me a better sense of what interests me."*

3 "Why this firm?"

I would give a reason grounded in this office or practice and explain why it matters to me. Replace general praise with something verified, and do not imply that reading an attorney's biography is the same as knowing them.

> *"I'm exploring [practice], and the [office] team's work on [verified public matter or topic] caught my attention because [real reason]. I'd like to understand how juniors contribute to that work and whether the program would let me explore [specific interest]."*

4 "Why this city?"

Give the actual reason, including personal connections if you want to share them, and explain what you have learned about working there. I would not invent ties or promise to stay forever.

> *"I'm interested in [city] because [true personal or professional reason]. I've been learning about its [practice or industry] work through [actual research or conversations], and I want to build a clearer picture of what starting my career here would involve."*

5 "What practice are you interested in?"

You can show direction without pretending the decision is final. Explain what interests you about the work and what you are doing to test that interest.

> *"I'm most interested in [A] and [B] at the moment. I enjoyed [real task or subject], which drew me toward them, but I haven't understood how the junior experience differs. I've been [actual exploration] to get a more concrete picture."*

6 "Walk me through this experience on your resume."

Separate your own responsibility from what the team or organization accomplished. A modest contribution you can explain is better than taking credit for a result you did not produce.

> *"The team was trying to [goal], and I was responsible for [specific contribution]. When [problem] came up, I [action], which led to [true outcome]. The part I would approach differently now is [specific reflection]."*

7 "Tell me about a difficult teammate or a disagreement."

Explain the work problem without turning the other person into a villain, then show how you tried to resolve it. An imperfect outcome can still support a useful answer.

> *"On a student project, we disagreed about what needed to be finished first. I asked us to compare the deadline and divide the remaining work explicitly, which helped us finish, although I should have raised the coordination problem earlier."*

8 "Tell me about a mistake or difficult feedback."

I would choose a real example I can discuss appropriately, acknowledge my role, and show what I changed. Avoid confidential details and a story in which the only mistake was caring too much.

> *"I sent a draft before checking whether it answered the question my supervisor wanted resolved. After the feedback, I restated the task and revised it, and on later assignments I began confirming the intended use before drafting."*

9 "How do you handle competing deadlines?"

Show how you gather information, communicate, and prioritize, rather than simply say you work harder. If it is hypothetical, describe what you would do without pretending it already happened.

> *"I would clarify what each assignment requires and when the work is actually needed, then tell the relevant supervisors where the conflict is. I would use the team's staffing process to agree on priorities rather than silently choose which deadline to miss."*

10 "What is a weakness you are working on?"

Choose something genuine, describe its effect, and explain an action you are taking. I would not dress a strength up as a weakness or claim the issue has disappeared without evidence.

> *"I can put too much background into an early draft, which makes the main point harder to find. I've been asking what decision the reader needs to make and moving material that does not serve it out of the opening."*

11 "Can you explain this grade or part of your transcript?"

Respond to what was asked without becoming defensive or inventing an explanation. You can take responsibility and describe a concrete adjustment without promising a result you do not have yet.

> *"That result was below what I wanted. After reviewing [actual feedback], I realized I needed to change [specific approach], and I've been working on it through [real action]. I don't have a later result yet, so I can speak to the change rather than claim an improvement already."*

12 "Where else are you interviewing?"

Answer truthfully and at a level you are comfortable sharing, and explain the connection between your choices if there is one. Do not invent offers or deadlines to seem more desirable.

> *"I'm exploring [actual types of offices or practices] because [reason]. I would prefer to keep the specific firms private at this stage, but I'm happy to explain what I'm looking for and any real timing constraints relevant to this process."*

13 "What would you bring to the team?"

I would choose a quality I can support with an actual example rather than compare myself to candidates I do not know. Keep the claim proportionate to what the experience shows.

> *"In [real role], I was responsible for [task], and I learned to make [specific contribution] useful to the rest of the team. For example, [brief true action and result]. I'd like to bring that habit with me while learning the legal work."*

14 "What questions do you have for me?"

Use something from the conversation or your research, and ask a question this person is well placed to answer. You do not need a complicated question to prove preparation.

> *"You mentioned that juniors work with several teams early on. How did that affect the way you found people to learn from, and was there anything you wish you had understood about the process when you joined?"*

Before using any sample, I would practice saying the idea in my own words and check that every factual detail is true. If the real experience involves a client, employer, or court, choose details you are allowed to share or use another example. The point is to make your reasoning easier to follow, not to sound as if you have memorized the "right" personality.

15 "What have you heard about us?"

This is the same test as "why this firm," asked in a way that catches a rehearsed answer. Say what you actually know and where you learned it, including if the answer is one conversation and an hour on their site.

16 "Litigation or transactional?"

A blunter version of the practice question, and at the 1L stage a direction is a complete answer. Saying you are still testing both is fine if you can say what you are testing.

17 "Where do you see yourself in five years?"

I would answer about the kind of work and the kind of lawyer, not a title or a partnership timeline. Certainty you do not have is easy to hear.

18 "What was your favorite class, and your hardest one?"

A specific answer is more useful than a safe one. The hard class is the more interesting half, because what you did about it says more than the grade.

19 "Tell me about a time you worked on a team."

Plain teamwork, with no conflict required. Describe what you were responsible for and how the group actually divided the work.

20 "Tell me about a challenge or a setback, or a time you took initiative."

One prepared story can usually answer all three if you know what it shows. What changed afterward matters more than how hard it was.

21 "What are you looking for in a firm?"

Different from the practice question, and often a better one. Answer in terms of how work arrives and how people learn, rather than listing adjectives any firm would claim.

22 "Is there anything not on your resume that we should know?"

An invitation, not a trap. Have one real thing ready, and treat it as a chance to add rather than to apologize.

The screening interview

A screener is the short first conversation. The questions are the ones above; what changes is how much room you get to answer them.

Before a callback there is usually a screener, sometimes called a pre-screen. Accounts of it are consistent on the shape: roughly fifteen to thirty minutes, sometimes with recruiting staff and sometimes with an associate or a partner, and increasingly on video. Its purpose is to decide whether you go to a callback, not to make a decision about hiring you.

What that length does to the conversation is the thing worth preparing for. A screener often does not get past three or four questions, and students who have been through recent cycles tend to describe much the same small core: tell me about yourself, why this firm, something about what you want to practise, and one behavioural story. The long explanation you prepared about a transcript or a career change will usually not be asked for, and volunteering it uses up the time you needed for the question that was asked.

So I would prepare the same material as for a callback and then prepare to use less of it. Sixty to ninety seconds for the opening answer rather than three minutes. One behavioural story told fully rather than three told partly. Three or four questions ready at the end, because being asked what you want to know and having nothing is a worse signal in fifteen minutes than it is in an hour.

Two practical notes. If a screen is offered during your exams, it is reasonable to ask for a date afterwards, and recruiters generally expect that request. And if the screen is on video, the first thirty seconds are part of it: check the link and the camera before the day rather than during it.

The shape is consistent enough to prepare against. The specifics will vary by office and by whoever is on the call.

What a callback actually looks like

The questions above are only useful once you know the shape of the day they are asked in.

A screener is the first conversation, usually short, often one interviewer, and increasingly held online. If it goes well, a callback follows, and the callback is the longer one. Expect to meet several attorneys in sequence, typically in separate conversations of twenty to thirty minutes each, sometimes with a meal attached. The meal is part of the day, not a break from it, though treating it as an interrogation is its own mistake.

Send a thank-you note afterward. The convention is a short message to each person you met, within a day or so, referring to something that was actually said. Practice on this point is not unanimous, and some attorneys will tell you they barely register them, so write them because they are easy and occasionally remembered, not because one will decide the outcome.

Much of this now happens on video. Test the camera and the link before the day rather than during it, put the light in front of you, and look at the lens when you are making a point. Have the written materials you might need where you can reach them without obviously reading. A silence on video is longer than a silence in a room, so let the other person finish rather than filling it.

08

Summer Work

Q8 How do I make my 1L summer useful if it is not at a firm

If the question is whether a summer will help you become better at legal work, the employer's name does not tell you everything you need to know. I would also ask what you will produce, who will review it, and whether you will have an opportunity to improve after receiving comments. That can be worth investigating in a court, government office, nonprofit, research role, firm, or another appropriate setting, rather than treating everything outside a firm as a consolation prize.

At the beginning, I would ask my supervisor, "What would a successful summer look like from your perspective, and when would it be useful for us to check in?" That gives you something concrete to work toward and a basis for a later conversation about what improved. Keep notes about your own learning without retaining confidential information, and obtain the relevant permission before keeping work or using a writing sample. I do think you should leave with a clearer account of what you learned, but you should be able to tell that story without disclosing the organization's protected work or pretending the experience settled your entire career direction.

Two routes worth knowing about, both of them outside the main 2L cycle.

The first is a 1L summer associate programme at a firm. These exist, they run on their own calendar rather than the 2L one, and the number of places is small relative to the number of applicants.

The second is the pipeline and fellowship programmes, and the first thing to get straight about them is when they happen. SEO Law's Fellowship is the best known, and it is a pre-law programme rather than a 1L one: as its own published requirements stood in November 2026, you apply while you are applying to law school, for the summer before you start. If you are reading this as a 1L, that intake is already behind you, although the support continues through law school for those who are in it. Other programmes, including firm-run ones and consortium programmes such as LCLD, sit on their own calendars, so ask your career office by name which of them a current 1L can still apply to. One further caution: since 2025 a number of firms have changed the eligibility conditions attached to such programmes under legal pressure, and some have withdrawn from them. Anything written about them goes stale quickly, including this paragraph. Check the programme's own site for the current year before you plan around it.

Q9 What matters during a 2L summer beyond being sociable

Consider what happens when someone gives you an assignment and hears nothing until the deadline. Even if you have been working hard, they may not know whether you understood the question, whether you are waiting on something, or whether another assignment has taken over your time. I would pay attention to that gap, because being reliable involves making the work understandable to the people depending on it, not just privately putting in the effort.

When an assignment comes in, confirm the question, intended audience, format, and deadline, and if you are unsure, do enough initial thinking to ask a focused question. If the workload conflicts with something already assigned, say so early: "I'm working toward Thursday's deadline on another assignment, and this looks like it may take [estimate]. How should we coordinate priorities?" Follow the program's staffing process rather than quietly choosing which person will be disappointed. When you submit, explain the result and anything unresolved, and if you make a mistake, raise it instead of hoping it stays invisible. Social events can help you know people,

but I would not confuse being enjoyable at dinner with being dependable on an assignment, and neither is a guarantee of a return offer.

IN PRACTICE

If there is a particular type of work you are interested in, do not hesitate to ask for it. The summer is meant to be a learning experience, and attorneys generally understand that you are still exploring your interests.

The other thing nobody warns a summer associate about is the rhythm of the work.

IN PRACTICE

Transactional work can be quite unpredictable and often comes in waves. There were weeks when things were really slow for me, and other weeks when I was extremely busy. My advice is not to panic during a slow week. It does not necessarily mean you are doing anything wrong, or that people do not want to work with you. Sometimes there simply are not many active deals or assignments available. Things can pick up very quickly, so enjoy the downtime when you have it, and be ready when the work comes.

IN PRACTICE

If you have free time, send emails to lawyers and ask them to chat or have lunch. Listen to their experience in the group, and if you are interested in it, ask them to keep you in mind. If you are a summer, it is never your fault that you do not have work. If you have too much work, try to avoid that from the beginning. As a summer you should not have a lot of work, and if you find yourself at risk of missing a deadline, communicate now. Again, as a summer, nothing should actually be urgent. It is almost guaranteed that the answer will be: fine, just do it by tomorrow.

Two lines in that account need a boundary around them. Treat every deadline you are given as real until the person who gave it to you says otherwise: if two assignments collide, or a deadline is at risk, tell the assigning lawyer and whoever runs staffing, and ask them to decide the order, because

an extension is not yours until someone confirms it. And a quiet week usually does not mean you are doing anything wrong — the contributor above says the same thing from a different firm — but that is a reassurance rather than a rule, and the useful response is the one this contributor gives first, which is to go and ask.

IN PRACTICE

You really do not need to worry about whether you are busy enough as a summer associate. No one expects summer associates to have a lot of billable work, and people generally are not focused on whether you are doing enough of it. I would prioritise getting to know people and grabbing coffee with them, especially people in the group you think you might want to join. Networking is honestly more important than working a lot during the summer. That said, when you do get billable work, make sure you do a great job and try to impress the people you are working with. Once you actually start as an associate there are fewer opportunities to meet people across different groups, so the summer is really the best time to reach out and figure out which group you would like to join.

Read those two against what this chapter said earlier, because they do not line up neatly. We wrote that being enjoyable at dinner is not the same as being dependable on an assignment. A contributor who is now practising says networking matters more during a summer than the volume of work does. Both can be true at once: the work you are given still has to be done properly, and the hours you log are not what the summer is measuring.

What reconciles them is quality rather than volume, on both sides. A summer spent meeting a great many people badly is not better than one where a few people remember the conversation. Asking each person in turn where they are from produces a stack of exchanges nobody retains, yourself included. Go in with something you actually want to understand about their work, and the conversation has somewhere to go.

I would also be careful with the version of this that turns into looking for the people you happen to click with. Deciding where to spend your attention by who you have chemistry with is a mistake about what the room is. This is a professional setting, not a social one, and it is certainly not dating. The

question is not who you enjoyed talking to. It is whose work you want to understand, and who would want a junior like you on it.

09

Your First Year as an Associate

The work does not change as much as you expect. What changes is who is responsible for finding it.

This guide has so far stopped where the summer ends, which is where most guides stop and where the job actually starts. We are opening this chapter because the contributors who are furthest along told us the same thing in different words, and it was not what we expected them to say.

What they did not say is that the work gets harder, or that the standard jumps. What they said is that the search for work becomes yours.

One scope note before the accounts. Both of these people are transactional associates at firms where work is distributed through an internal free market rather than assigned centrally. Where staffing is centralised, or in a litigation group that runs standing case teams, less of this will hold. Read it as two people's experience of a particular system rather than as how a first year works everywhere.

IN PRACTICE

Once you start as a first-year, the expectations change pretty quickly. You will be expected to take more ownership of your workload and your career, so be proactive about reaching out and asking for work. That is particularly important at free-market firms, where there is no centralised system assigning matters to associates. Do not assume that work will automatically come to you. Firms do not expect every first-year they hire to stay forever, and at some firms associates who consistently do not get enough work may eventually be pushed out. You need to take some responsibility for building your own pipeline of work and relationships. At the same time, do not overreact if you are slow at the beginning. It is completely normal to have a ramp-up period during your first few months. Keep reaching out, and when you do get work, focus on doing it really well. Once people know that you are reliable and produce good work, they will be much more likely to come back to you. And do not only network with partners. Get to know mid-level and senior associates as well. In practice they are often the ones deciding which juniors to bring onto their deals, since they work with junior associates most directly.

That last point is worth separating out, because it inverts the instinct. A student optimising for partners is optimising for the people least likely to be choosing the junior on a given deal.

The second thing we were told is what the work itself consists of, which students picture very badly. It is less legal and more custodial than the word associate suggests, and that is not a complaint.

IN PRACTICE

As a first-year associate, pay attention to details and take ownership of everything you are assigned. If you own the closing checklist, really own it. Read the emails, know the status of every document, understand what is outstanding, and follow what is happening on the deal. Your assignments may not involve much substantive law at first, but they will test whether you are careful and reliable. Avoid small mistakes: typos, grammatical errors, formatting problems, missed instructions, inconsistencies. Proofread everything. Also, use precedents. Transactional lawyers learn from prior deals. Before asking a question, look for a precedent, ask whether the senior has one you should follow, and use the resources available to you, including approved AI tools, to understand the issue. Then, if you still need help, ask a focused question. Finally, do not panic when you receive an unfamiliar assignment. First-years are not expected to know everything. Understand exactly what the senior wants, think through the task, and work out how to get it done.

Note the order in that last part. Look for a precedent, ask whether there is one you should be following, use what you have, and then ask a specific question. The thing being tested is not whether you knew, it is whether you did the work before you asked.

The third thing is the most reassuring, and it came from someone who had recently made the transition.

IN PRACTICE

Do not take a redline personally. And I do not think it is too different from the summer: you still do not know anything, and people still love to answer any stupid question you have. Make sure you ask AI first.

Read that last sentence next to the fuller version two notes above: use the resources available to you, including approved AI tools, and then ask a focused question. Three things are doing the work in that order. Use the tools your firm has approved, not the ones you use at home, and keep client and matter information out of anything that has not been approved for it. Check what comes back before it leaves your desk, because once you send it

on it is your work and you are answerable for it. And do not let the habit of trying first delay a question about scope, priority or confidentiality: those go to a person, early, and asking them is not a failure to have tried.

Two readings of that are both correct. The transition is smaller than the anxiety around it suggests. And the obligation to have tried before you ask does not go away when you become the person being paid.

10

If You Are an International Student, an LLM, or a Transfer

We have nothing like the experience here that we have elsewhere in this guide, and we would rather say so than write a confident chapter about someone else's situation.

This is the thinnest chapter in the guide, and we would rather it be filled in by people who have lived it than completed by us.

What we can say now is where the differences sit, so that you know what to ask about rather than discovering it late.

Work authorisation is a real variable in this process and firms differ in how they handle it. Some state plainly that they sponsor; others do not say, which is not the same as a no. The question of when it comes up in a process, and who to ask, is worth settling early with your career office rather than guessing at it from a firm's website.

The LLM route is structurally different from the JD route rather than a smaller version of it. The calendar, the number of positions and the markets where they concentrate are not the same, and advice written for JD recruiting can mislead if it is applied without adjustment.

Transfer students face a timing problem specifically. Transfer decisions often arrive after the 2L summer cycle described earlier has largely run, so the standard calendar does not fit. The mistake is to wait for the decision. Recruit from where you are: use your current school's career office and whatever recruiting it runs, apply on the ordinary calendar, and then work the sequence out with the career office at the school you arrive at. Several schools tell prospective transfers exactly this, because so much 2L hiring is finished before transfer admissions are.

If you have been through any of this, we would like to hear from you, and this chapter will be better in the next edition than it is in this one.

11

Working With People

Q10 How do I build relationships with peers without making everything competitive

When everyone is entering the same recruiting process, it can become very easy to treat ordinary conversations as a way to figure out who is ahead, especially when people are comparing interviews, assignments, or offers. I do think you can take your own goals seriously without making every lunch another measurement of where you stand. A peer is also someone you can learn from, work alongside, and simply enjoy spending time with, which gets lost if every interaction has to produce an advantage.

You can start with ordinary things, such as inviting someone to walk to an event, sharing useful logistical information, or giving credit when they helped you. If you disagree on a joint task, talk about the work and responsibilities rather than building a group against the other person. None of this requires sharing private recruiting news, circulating work product without permission, or secretly taking over someone else's assignment. I would keep those boundaries clear, because being a good colleague should not require either person to give up their privacy or responsibility for their own work.

Q11 How should I interact with partners and senior lawyers

If you are speaking with someone much more senior, it can be tempting to either stay almost silent or turn the conversation into a demonstration of how much you know. I would try to make the interaction useful instead, which in a work setting means explaining what you found, what you are unsure about, and what you need from them. Preparation helps, but pretending uncertainty does not exist makes it harder for the other person to help you think through it.

In a social setting, you can let the conversation be more ordinary and follow what the person seems interested in discussing, without forcing every opening into a request for mentorship. At an appropriate moment, I might ask, "When you review a junior's draft, what makes it easier to give useful feedback?" and listen for something I could apply. I would also respect the team around the work. Going around the person supervising an assignment simply to be seen by someone senior can create confusion, while direct contact makes sense when the assignment, invitation, or team process calls for it. The difference is the reason for the contact, not how impressive the person's title is.

Q12 How should I communicate with recruiting professionals

If a recruiting contact opens your email between other scheduling requests, the message should give them enough context to understand the issue without reconstructing your situation. I would include my name, the office or program, where I am in the process, and the specific question, then leave out the extra language that makes a simple request harder to answer. Recruiting professionals are people you are working with in the process, not a barrier you need to get around to reach a lawyer.

For example, if another offer has a response deadline, I would state the actual date: "I'm interviewing for [program and office] and have another response deadline on [date]. Is there any update you can share about timing? I understand you may not be able to accelerate the process." That

communicates the issue without creating urgency that does not exist. Ask the designated contact about logistics, and if a matter is sensitive, find out which channel should handle it before copying a large group. For questions about commitments or how to assess your options, involve your career office as needed. I would not assume recruiting can promise a particular team, and would ask who actually owns that decision.

Q13 What if I meet clients at a firm event

If you are invited to an event with clients, your role matters. You may be a student or summer associate meeting people through the firm, which does not mean you are expected to sell legal services or answer questions on the firm's behalf. I would introduce myself accurately, follow the host lawyer's lead, and allow the conversation to be a normal conversation rather than try to prove expertise I do not have.

If someone raises a work question, you can say, "I'm a summer associate, so I should connect you with [host] on that question." There is no need to improvise legal advice, promise what the firm can do, or discuss nonpublic work to keep the interaction moving. I would also ask before initiating a work related follow up or using contact information obtained through the event, because being included in a conversation is not the same thing as being authorized to manage the relationship. Different hosts and organizations may have different expectations, so I would clarify those instead of applying a generic networking rule.

12

Keeping Options Open

Q14 What can I learn from alumni who are clerking

A clerk's experience may help you think about research, writing, feedback, and whether you want to explore a clerkship, but the conversation needs to stay within what that person is permitted to discuss. I would ask about habits that can be described without discussing particular matters or internal deliberations, such as, "Is there a writing habit you would encourage a 1L to build now?" That gives the person room to share something useful without being asked to speak for a judge or court.

If a question is off limits, move on rather than asking for the same information anonymously. I would not ask how a judge will decide a matter, what was said in chambers, or for private assessments of the lawyers appearing there. And if an alumnus is contributing to this guide, we need their confirmation of the applicable permission requirements before including the contribution. Their career path can give us questions to investigate, but I would not turn one person's route into a prediction of our own prospects or treat their personal advice as an institutional endorsement.

Q15 What if I still do not know what I want

When someone says, "I'm open to anything," I can understand the intention, but it leaves the other person with very little to respond to. If instead you explain that you are exploring 2 areas, what interests you about each, and the difference you have not understood, the uncertainty becomes a real

conversation. You can say, "I'm exploring [A] and [B]. I like [specific feature], but I haven't understood [specific difference] yet," without pretending you have already made the decision.

I would turn that conversation into one manageable next step, whether that is comparing 2 kinds of assignments, learning about an office, or speaking with someone whose work you do not yet understand. Keep actual application requirements separate from the exploration, so not knowing your final direction does not become a reason to miss an opportunity's deadline. If you start 1L in fall 2026, summer 2027 is your 1L summer and summer 2028 is your 2L summer, and you still need to confirm the target summer on each posting. I do think you can be honest about not knowing and serious about finding out at the same time, which is a better place to begin than borrowing someone else's certainty.

NOTE

The Editorial Committee

Drafted and designed by Asian American attorneys at Am Law 100 firms, with contributions from current law students.

Students named with their permission: CJ Cai, Clementine Pan, Joseph Zhao. None of the attorneys is named in this edition.

Initiated by Charles Zuo, and finished by his generous, decent, and brave friends.

It does not represent the position of any law firm. Everyone who contributed wrote in a personal capacity.

NOTE

How This Guide Was Written

This guide started halfway through a Manhattan Sunset. A message came in asking what an Am Law firm is, and then what the difference is between tax and tax controversy. Both answers took longer than the questions suggested they would, and by the end of the drink the point was obvious: nobody at that table had been told any of this either. We had each worked it out late and in pieces, mostly by asking people who were kind enough not to make us feel stupid. You should be able to get through a bar review without quietly wondering what the acronym on a firm's website stands for.

When the guide says "I" or "we," it reflects the view of one of our editors or of a group of editors.

The passages set apart under the heading In practice are different. Those are contributors' own accounts, in their own words, edited only for length and clarity and published with their permission. We have deliberately not put a name against each one. What a particular person got wrong in a particular semester is their business, and attaching it to them by name would make honesty more expensive than it should be.

Some of what shaped this edition was given to us on the understanding that it would not be attributed to anyone, and it has not been.

Part of this guide was drafted in a café in Streeterville, where, somewhere between two sentences, a bag left the back of a chair and took with it every piece of identification its owner was carrying. The note about where to keep your bag, in the chapter on recruiting conversations, was written afterwards.

One note on scope. This guide describes recruiting for United States law firms by students in a JD programme, and where it cites a school's own policy that school is Northwestern. Other schools publish their own, and they differ. The appendices were checked more recently than the date on the cover and carry their own dates.

If you went through this and would be willing to write a paragraph about it, we would like to hear from you. The next edition will be better than this one in exactly the places where someone tells us what actually happened.

Write to editor@breakingintobiglaw.com. Put subscribe in the subject line and you will hear when a new edition is out. Write anything else to the same address — a correction, a disagreement, a paragraph about your own year — and it reaches the committee.

If you want to know what to send, these are the thinnest parts of this edition: what a 1L summer inside a firm is actually like, the chapter for international students, LLMs and transfers, and what a first year looks like outside transactional work.

APPENDIX A

Am Law 100

2026 edition. Ranked by gross revenue. I would use this list to find firms to research, not to decide which firm or office is right for me. Revenue does not tell us what work a junior lawyer will do, how a team teaches, or whether a firm is recruiting for a particular summer.

Source: Am Law 100. 2026 edition, based on 2025 gross revenue, checked on 18 September 2026. The Tableau chart uses shortened firm names, and verein tags are retained as shown.

Ranks and revenue are the publisher's, and so are the names they were published under. Where a firm has since combined and carries on under a new name, the entry reads "ranked name — now combined name", so that the ranking stays with the firm that earned it and you still have the name to search for today. Where a firm was absorbed into another entry on this list, or is no longer a place a student can apply to, its rank is left out and the numbering has gaps. These are working directories adapted from the published lists, not complete reproductions of them. Updated 9 November 2026.

AM LAW 100

Ranks 1 to 50

1	Kirkland
2	Latham
3	DLA Piper (verein)
4	Gibson Dunn
5	Skadden
6	Sidley
7	Ropes & Gray
8	Baker McKenzie (verein)
9	White & Case
10	Simpson Thacher
11	Morgan Lewis
12	Hogan Lovells — now Hogan Lovells Cadwalader
13	Paul Weiss
14	Davis Polk
15	Jones Day
16	McDermott Will & Emery — now McDermott Will & Schulte
17	Greenberg Traurig
18	Dentons (verein)
19	Norton Rose (verein)
20	Quinn Emanuel
21	Goodwin Procter
22	Paul Hastings
23	King & Spalding
24	Cooley
25	Sullivan & Cromwell
26	Holland & Knight
27	Mayer Brown
28	Milbank
30	Covington
31	Willkie
32	Cleary Gottlieb
33	Troutman Pepper Locke
34	Orrick
35	Debevoise
36	Akin
37	Wilson Sonsini
38	Wilmer
39	Dechert
40	Reed Smith
41	Proskauer
42	Morrison & Foerster
43	Foley & Lardner
44	Alston & Bird
45	Squire Patton (verein)
46	Wachtell
47	Sheppard
48	K&L Gates
49	Winston & Strawn — now Winston Taylor
50	Cravath

Ranks 51 to 100

51	Perkins Coie — now Ashurst Perkins Coie
52	Fried Frank
53	Arnold & Porter
54	McGuireWoods
55	Polsinelli
56	Faegre Drinker
57	O'Melveny
58	Vinson & Elkins
59	Baker & Hostetler
60	Nelson Mullins
61	Taft
62	Littler
63	Seyfarth
64	Hunton Andrews
65	Pillsbury
66	Katten
67	Bryan Cave
68	Venable
69	Fenwick
70	Gordon Rees
71	Fox Rothschild
72	Lewis Brisbois
73	Blank Rome
74	Fragomen
75	Baker Botts
76	Womble Bond
77	Ogletree Deakins
78	Barnes & Thornburg
79	Jackson Lewis
80	Cozen O'Connor
81	Jenner & Block
82	Husch Blackwell
83	Mintz Levin
84	Duane Morris
85	Haynes and Boone
86	Crowell & Moring
87	Williams & Connolly
88	Nixon Peabody
89	Ballard Spahr
90	Davis Wright
91	ArentFox Schiff
92	Susman Godfrey
93	Shook Hardy
94	Wilson Elser
95	Kilpatrick Townsend
96	Akerman
98	Steptoe
99	Dorsey
100	Bradley Arant

APPENDIX B

Vault Law 100

2027 edition. This list ranks perceived prestige based on associates' assessments of other firms. It is not a ranking of training, working hours or the fit of a particular office. I would use it to find names to research, then investigate the practice, office and people separately. The edition year follows Vault's published label. Some listings are marked as legacy profiles; check current firm names and recruiting pages before reaching out.

Source: Vault Law 100. Ranks follow the publisher's list, checked on 18 September 2026.

Names are handled in the same way as in Appendix A, including the "ranked name — now combined name" entries and the gaps where a rank has been left out. Updated 9 November 2026.

VAULT LAW 100

Ranks 1 to 50

1	Cravath, Swaine & Moore LLP
2	Wachtell, Lipton, Rosen & Katz
3	Skadden
4	Latham & Watkins
5	Sullivan & Cromwell LLP
6	Kirkland & Ellis
7	Davis Polk & Wardwell LLP
8	Gibson Dunn
9	Milbank LLP
10	Simpson Thacher
11	Sidley Austin LLP
12	Covington & Burling
13	Paul, Weiss, Rifkind, Wharton & Garrison LLP
14	Quinn Emanuel Urquhart & Sullivan, LLP
16	Cleary Gottlieb Steen & Hamilton
17	Williams & Connolly LLP
18	White & Case
19	Susman Godfrey
20	Ropes & Gray LLP
21	Paul Hastings LLP
22	Cooley
23	Debevoise & Plimpton LLP
24	Perkins Coie — now Ashurst Perkins Coie
25	WilmerHale
26	Jones Day
27	Morrison Foerster
28	O'Melveny & Myers LLP
29	Munger, Tolles & Olson LLP
30	Hogan Lovells — now Hogan Lovells Cadwalader
31	Goodwin
32	Arnold & Porter Kaye Scholer LLP
33	Proskauer Rose LLP
34	Wilson Sonsini
35	Willkie Farr & Gallagher LLP
36	King & Spalding LLP
37	Morgan, Lewis & Bockius LLP
38	Akin Gump Strauss Hauer & Feld LLP
39	Winston & Strawn LLP — now Winston Taylor LLP
40	Orrick
41	Clifford Chance US LLP
42	DLA Piper LLP (US)
43	Jenner & Block
44	Mayer Brown LLP
45	Baker McKenzie
46	McDermott Will & Emery — now McDermott Will & Schulte
47	Fried, Frank, Harris, Shriver & Jacobson LLP
48	Holland & Knight LLP
49	K&L Gates LLP
50	Freshfields US LLP

VAULT LAW 100

Ranks 51 to 100

51	Dechert
52	Linklaters
53	Vinson & Elkins
54	Baker Botts L.L.P.
55	Greenberg Traurig, LLP
56	A&O Shearman
57	Norton Rose Fulbright
58	Alston & Bird
59	Reed Smith LLP
60	Pillsbury
61	Boies Schiller Flexner LLP
62	Dentons US LLP
63	BakerHostetler
65	Crowell & Moring
66	Sheppard
67	Foley & Lardner LLP
68	McGuireWoods
69	Venable LLP
70	Kellogg Hansen
71	Fenwick
72	Troutman Pepper Locke
73	Cahill Gordon & Reindel LLP
74	Davis Wright Tremaine LLP
75	Nixon Peabody LLP
76	Fox Rothschild
77	Mintz
78	Katten Muchin Rosenman LLP
79	Steptoe LLP
80	ArentFox Schiff LLP
81	Haynes and Boone, LLP
82	Squire Patton Boggs (US) LLP
83	Gunderson Dettmer Stough Villeneuve Franklin & Hachigian, LLP
84	Fish & Richardson P.C.
85	Faegre Drinker
86	Irell & Manella LLP
87	Polsinelli
88	Cozen O'Connor
89	Seyfarth
90	Foley Hoag LLP
91	Blank Rome LLP
92	Ballard Spahr
93	Hunton Andrews Kurth LLP
94	Duane Morris LLP
95	Akerman
96	Husch Blackwell LLP
97	Kilpatrick
98	Eversheds Sutherland (US) LLP
99	BCLP
100	Littler Mendelson P.C.